

What is it?

Mobile technology was introduced over a decade ago in India to facilitate communication — primarily with SMS and voice. However, over the years, mobile phones have become an integral part of our lives. A popular cellphone ad says: “It’s who we are.” And rightly so, for a simple SMS or ring tone or even our caller tunes reveal a significant part of our personalities. This is where the telecom companies are realising the potential of offering services beyond just being a way of communication.

However, mVAS comes at a price and cellular operators and service providers charge a premium rate for the services they offer other than basic communication. Some of the services include SMS (text messages), MMS (multimedia messages), USSD (unstructured supplementary services data), CRBT (caller ring back tone), video streaming, participation in polls and contests, location-based services, mCommerce (financial transactions), mobile advertisements, infotainment services (news, weather reports, songs, recipes), Instant messaging, content downloads (wallpapers, games, ring tones) and downloadable mobile applications.

Those are only a few that come to one’s mind the moment mVAS is mentioned. However, the list keeps changing as per the handset compatibilities and customer demands.

As an artist would create a new painting on each canvas, mobile VAS is also as creative and vast in its purview. You could be a writer of content, develop games for mobile phones, develop ecommerce platforms, technologies. In short, this career can be what you want it to be.

Today, mobile phones have become the primary source of entertainment and so consumer expectation is also shooting up with each passing day. Today, we check our emails on our phone. We also book movie tickets transact online through our cell phones.

The growth story

Mobile interconnected industries have been coming up with fresh and ground-breaking mobile technologies. Mobile VAS accounts for 10-12 per cent of total telecom revenues. There are over 375 million mobile subscribers in India, out of which 8-10 per cent are expected to be GPRS (general packet radio services) subscribers as well. With the launch of 3G services (faster data speed) in India, games download, mCommerce, video streaming, mobile blogs and mobile chat too are expected to grow.

As per TRAI predictions, mobile VAS revenue growth contributing to telecommunication industry is expected to grow to 30% in the next 5-7 years, which is way beyond the current contribution of 10–12%. Many experts are predicting mobile VAS in India to be a \$1-billion market by 2010.

With the advent of mobile 2.0, cellular phones have become modes of emailing, social networking (twitter), seconds as a camera, a mobile wallet and much more.

As computers develop and new technologies come up in the computing world, there will be the demand to make them available on mobile handsets as well. And as projected by NASSCOM, the software industry is going to grow even in these recessionary times, mobile application and VAS industry

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